

MODULE 3: LANGUAGE FOCUS PRIME LANGUAGE ACADEMY

Le Plus-que-Parfait Continu -The Past Perfect Continuous

This handout will explain the French past perfect continuous tense, "le plus-que-parfait continu."

Section 1: Situations of Use (Situations d'Utilisation)

- Nous utilisons le passé parfait continu pour parler d'une action **qui a commencé dans le passé et qui s'est poursuivie jusqu'à une autre action passée.**

Grammatical Structure:

The past perfect continuous is formed with: **Had+been+Verb-ing**

- Subject**
- Auxiliary verb ("Have" conjugated in the imperfect tense)**
- Been (été) + present participle (verbe en train de + infinitive)**

Examples :

- J'avais été en train de courir (I **had been running**) quand je l'ai vu(e). = **when I saw** him/her)
- Elle avait été en train de pleuvoir (It **had been raining**) toute la journée. = **all day**)
- Nous avions été en train de travailler (We **had been working**) sur le projet depuis des semaines. = **for weeks**)

Note: "Être en train de" is the most common way to express a continuous action in French. However, other verbs like "continuer à" (to continue to) or "être occupé à" (to be busy doing) can also be used.

Section 2: Negative Form

Situations of Use (Situations d'Utilisation):

Same as the affirmative form, to talk about an action that **started in the past and continued up to another past action**, but negated.

Grammatical Structure:

Not (ne) + auxiliary verb (conjugated in the imperfect tense) Hadn't+been verb-ing (verbe en train de + infinitive)

Examples:

- Je n'avais pas été en train de courir (I **hadn't been running**) quand je l'ai vu(e).
- Elle n'avait pas été en train de pleuvoir (It **hadn't been raining**) toute la journée.
- Nous n'avions pas été en train de travailler (We **hadn't been working**) sur le projet depuis des semaines.

Section 3: Interrogative Form (Forme Interrogative)

How to Form a Question:

- To form a question in the past perfect continuous, invert the subject and the auxiliary verb.
- Use "Est-ce que..." (Is it that...) before the inverted subject and auxiliary verb for emphasis.

Examples:

Est-ce que j'avais été en train de courir quand je l'ai vu(e) ? (**Had I been running when I saw** him/her?)

More Examples:

- Étais-tu en train de dormir quand je t'ai appelé ? (**Had you been sleeping when I called** you?)

- Avaient-elles été en train de parler quand tu es entré ? (**Had** they **been talking** when you **came** in?)
- Étions-nous en train de manger quand il est arrivé ? (**Had** we **been eating** when he **arrived**?)

Section 4: Negative Interrogative Form

How to Form a Negative Question:

- Use the same structure as the negative form (**Hadn't+Subject+been verb-ing**), but start with "Est-ce que..." (Is it that...)

Example:

Est-ce que je n'**avais pas été en train de courir** quand je l'ai vu(e) ? (**Hadn't I been running** when I **saw** him/her?)

More Examples:

- N'étais-tu pas en train de dormir quand je t'ai appelé ? (**Hadn't you been sleeping** when I **called** you?)
- N'avaient-elles pas été en train de parler quand tu es entré ? (**Hadn't they been talking** when you **came** in?)
- N'étions-nous pas en train de manger quand il est arrivé ? (**Hadn't we been eating** when he **arrived**?)

Section 5: Active Voice vs. Passive Voice (Voix Active et Voix Passive)

The past perfect continuous can be used in both the active and passive voice.

Active Voice Example:

J'avais été en train de lire le livre pendant des heures quand il est tombé par terre. (I **had been reading** the book for hours **when** it fell to the ground.)

Passive Voice Example:

Le livre avait été lu pendant des heures quand il est tombé par terre. (The book **had been read** for hours **when** it fell to the ground.)

Note: The passive voice in the past perfect continuous is formed with:

- "Be" conjugated in the imperfect tense (e.g., j'étais, tu étais, il/elle était, etc.)
- Past participle of "Be" (been)
- Past participle of the main verb

Here are some additional points to consider:

- The active voice emphasizes the doer of the action (e.g., I had been reading the book).
- The passive voice emphasizes the recipient of the action (e.g., The book had been read).
- Not all verbs can be used in the passive voice.

More Examples:

Active Voice

- Nous avions été en train de préparer le dîner depuis le matin quand les invités sont arrivés. (We had been preparing dinner since the morning when the guests arrived.)
- Elle avait été en train de faire ses devoirs pendant toute l'après-midi quand sa mère l'a appelée. (She had been doing her homework all afternoon when her mother called her.)
- Ils avaient été en train de voyager pendant des semaines quand ils sont finalement rentrés chez eux. (They had been traveling for weeks when they finally returned home.)

Passive Voice

- Le dîner avait été préparé depuis le matin quand les invités sont arrivés. (Dinner had been prepared since the morning when the guests arrived.)
- Les devoirs avaient été faits pendant toute l'après-midi quand sa mère l'a appelée. (The homework had been done all afternoon when her mother called her.)
- Le voyage avait été effectué pendant des semaines quand ils sont finalement rentrés chez eux. (The trip had been made for weeks when they finally returned home.)

Worksheet

This worksheet will help you practice using the past perfect continuous tense in English.

Instructions:

1. Read the handout on the past perfect continuous tense.
2. Complete the following exercises.

Exercise 1: Affirmative Form

Fill in the blanks with the correct verb form (had been + present participle).

1. I (run) for an hour when I saw her.
2. It (rain) all day when we finally arrived home.
3. We (work) on the project for weeks before the deadline.
4. They (eat) dinner for an hour when the movie started.
5. You (sleep) soundly when I woke you up.

Exercise 2: Negative Form

Rewrite the following sentences in the negative form (had not been + present participle).

1. I had been running for an hour when I saw her. ->
2. It had been raining all day when we finally arrived home. ->
3. We had been working on the project for weeks before the deadline. ->
4. They had been eating dinner for an hour when the movie started. ->
5. You had been sleeping soundly when I woke you up. ->

Exercise 3: Interrogative Form

Write questions in the past perfect continuous tense using "Had."

1. I (run) for an hour when I saw her.
2. It (rain) all day when we finally arrived home.
3. We (work) on the project for weeks before the deadline.
4. They (eat) dinner for an hour when the movie started.
5. You (sleep) soundly when I woke you up.

Exercise 4: Negative Interrogative Form

Write questions in the negative past perfect continuous tense using "Hadn't."

1. I (run) for an hour when I saw her.
2. It (rain) all day when we finally arrived home.
3. We (work) on the project for weeks before the deadline.
4. They (eat) dinner for an hour when the movie started.
5. You (sleep) soundly when I woke you up.

Exercise 5: Active vs. Passive Voice

Rewrite the following sentences in the passive voice.

1. I had been reading the book for hours when it fell to the ground. ->
2. She had been preparing dinner since the morning when the guests arrived. ->

TEXT

The old attic creaked ominously under my feet as I sifted through forgotten treasures. Dust motes danced in the slivers of sunlight filtering through the grimy window. I had been exploring the attic for hours, each box and trunk revealing a forgotten memory. Here, nestled beneath a moth-eaten shawl, was my childhood teddy bear, its fur matted and its once-bright eyes cloudy with age. I had been clutching this very bear for comfort during countless childhood thunderstorms. A wave of nostalgia washed over me as I held it close, remembering the warmth and security it had offered.

Across the room, I saw a dusty trunk overflowing with old photographs. I knelt down and had been carefully sorting through them, each faded image a portal to a bygone era. Here I was, a carefree child, building sandcastles on the beach, the salty spray clinging to my hair. I had been giggling uncontrollably as a rogue wave washed over my creation, sending it tumbling down. The photo captured the pure joy of those carefree summer days.

As the afternoon sun began to dip below the horizon, casting long shadows across the attic floor, I realized it was time to pack up my discoveries. Though my muscles ached from hours of crouching and rummaging, a sense of contentment filled me. I had been revisiting a forgotten part of myself, a journey through the snapshots of time captured in these dusty keepsakes. The attic, once a place of mystery and forgotten things, now held a new meaning - a treasure trove of memories, each one whispering stories of my past.

DIALOGUE

Setting: Two friends, Sarah and Michael, are catching up at a cafe.

Sarah: Hey Michael, so sorry I'm late! Traffic had been horrendous, and I had been stuck in it for ages.

Michael: No worries, Sarah. I just arrived myself. What would you like to drink?

Sarah: I'll have a cappuccino, please. Thanks for asking. So, what have you been up to lately?

Michael: Well, I just finished volunteering at the animal shelter. I had been walking dogs all morning, and let me tell you, they were a handful!

Sarah: (laughing) I bet! How many did you walk?

Michael: Five! By the time I finished, I had been covered in fur and slobber, but it was definitely worth it. Those pups are adorable.

Sarah: That sounds like fun. I've been wanting to volunteer somewhere myself. Have you been volunteering there for a while?

Michael: Actually, this was my first time. I had been thinking about it for a while, and I finally decided to give it a try.

Sarah: That's great! Maybe we could volunteer together sometime.

Michael: Absolutely! I think you'd love it.

Sarah: Perfect! So, tell me more about these dogs you were walking. What were they like?

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